

Pahankanuwa Sermon #1

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

Taṇhāya jāyatī soko,

taṇhāya jāyatī bhayaṃ;

Taṇhāya vipṇamuttassa,

natthi soko kuto bhayaṃ.

From:

Verse 216 Piya Vagga (the Chapter on Affection) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Today is the Poson Full Moon Poya Day. As the day on which the Buddha's Dispensation was received by this island of ours, Poson Poya Day is a very valuable day for us. What is called the "Buddha's Dispensation" (*Buddha Śāsanaya*) is the Buddha's path of Dhamma, the path to Nibbāna. It is recorded that the Great Arahant Mahinda, having journeyed to the Mihintale rock with his companions, addressed King Devanampiyatissa as "Tissa, Tissa" to bestow this path of Dhamma—this path to Nibbāna—upon him. In that manner, having diverted the attention of the King—who was engaged in hunting deer, an unrighteous act—towards the Dhamma, the Great Arahant Mahinda systematically gifted the Buddha's path of Dhamma—the path to Nibbāna—to this island. The Buddha too did just this: he went in search of individuals who had the capacity to practice the Dhamma and realize the Dhamma, approaching even those in the poorest conditions if they were capable of receiving the gift of Dhamma—the realization of Dhamma—and bestowed this Buddha's Dispensation—that is, the path of Dhamma, the path to Nibbāna—upon them.

Now, in the background story related to the stanza we just recalled, we find how the Buddha carried the Buddha's Dispensation to a certain poor brahmin.

While the Buddha was residing at the Jetavana Monastery, a certain wrong-viewed (*mithyādiṣṭika*) brahmin was preparing a field. At that time, the Buddha arrived there. Since this brahmin held wrong views, even though he saw the Buddha from afar, he went on with his work as if he had not seen him. However, the Buddha walked right up to him and asked, "Brahmin, what are you doing?" The brahmin replied, "Venerable Gotama, I am preparing a field." That was all. The Buddha returned. On another day, this brahmin was plowing the field. On that day too, the Buddha went there. Having arrived, he asked, "Brahmin, what are you doing?" "Venerable Gotama, I am plowing." The Buddha returned. The man went on with his work. Next, on another day, the brahmin was sowing seeds in his field. On that day too, the Buddha went there. "Brahmin, what are you doing?" "Venerable Gotama, I am sowing." The conversation ended there too. The Buddha returned. Now the crop in the field was growing. One day, the brahmin was weeding the field. On that occasion too, the Buddha went there and asked, "Brahmin, what are you doing here?" "I am weeding, Venerable Gotama." Then came the time to guard the field. Now the paddy was ripening. On that occasion too, the Buddha went there. "What are you doing, Brahmin?" "I am guarding this field." "That apart, Venerable Gotama, you come to me constantly. You must be a friend of mine. From today, I accept you as my friend. When the harvest of this field is ripe, I will not consume it without giving a portion to you, Venerable Gotama," he promised. The Buddha also returned.

Now the paddy was ripe. With great expectations of harvesting the crop the following day, the brahmin went home. That night, a great torrential downpour accompanied by loud thunder fell, and the entire crop was washed away into the river just like that. In the morning, when the brahmin came to the field and looked, the entire field was desolate. An unbearable sorrow arose in him. He was most sorrowful because he could not give a portion of the harvest to his friend, Venerable Gotama. Somehow, this brahmin returned home, and due to that sorrow, he refused food—undertaking a fast—and went to sleep in a room. On that day too, the Buddha visited the brahmin's house, and having arrived, he asked, "Where is the lay disciple, the brahmin?" The household members said, "There he is, sleeping, unable to bear the sorrow of such a loss." The Buddha went there. "What is this, Brahmin?" he asked. The brahmin replied, "Venerable Gotama, I had such great expectations; I said that after the harvest is ripe, I would not consume it without giving a portion of it to you. Such a great destruction has befallen me. Because of the sorrow of it, I have refused food, given up expectation for life, and am lying down." The Buddha inquired, "Do you know the cause of this sorrow?" The brahmin said, "I do not know, do you

know?" "Yes, Brahmin, I know." It was on that occasion that he preached the stanza we recalled earlier:

Taṇhāya jāyatī soko

Taṇhāya jāyatī bhayaṃ

Taṇhāya vippamuttassa

Natthi soko kuto bhayaṃ

"Sorrow is born of craving (*taṇhā*), sorrow arises from craving (*taṇhā*). Fear is born of craving (*taṇhā*). For one freed from craving (*taṇhā*), there is no sorrow. Whence fear?" This is all the Buddha preached. Yet, it is recorded in the Dhamma that upon hearing this Dhamma, a great mental revolution occurred within the brahmin's mind, and through the systematic progress of insight-knowledge (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*), he realized the noble fruit of the path of stream-entry (*sotāpatti-magga-phala*).

Then, we must think a little about how such a great mental revolution occurred. How did these insight-knowledges arise? Insight (*vipassanā*) means a special seeing. That brahmin had gone home to sleep carrying the mental image of his field. What constantly came to his mind was that desolate field. The Buddha preached that stanza in a way that provided an opportunity for the brahmin, who was looking at that field, to look at his own mind. The brahmin thought that the sorrow arose because the field was ruined. But after the Buddha uttered that stanza, he must have realized that this sorrow arose not because the field was desolate, but because his mind was desolate. Along with the growth of the crop in that field, something else had grown. The desire in his mind had also sprouted and grown—things to be done with this harvest, and so many other things. You devotees know, those who engage in agriculture, with what a massive bundle of expectations the paddy grows. In that very way, various desires and expectations grew like weeds in this brahmin's mind. When the torrential rain destroyed the crop and washed it down the river, all those desires and expectations were washed away. At that time, the brahmin was constantly bringing up the sight of that ruined field in his mind. Because of that, he lamented, grieved, and sorrowed. The revolution created by the Buddha's stanza was so great that instead of looking at the field, the brahmin looked within; he looked at his mind. Virtuous friends, the word used in the Dhamma for this looking within is *Yoniso manasikāra* (Wise attention)—wise reflection. Wholesome or unwholesome states arise from the mind. Mind is the forerunner of everything. The Buddha has declared: "*Manopubbaṅgamā dhammā manoseṭṭhā manomayā*" and so forth. "Mind is the forerunner of all states, mind is chief, they are mind-made." It has

been declared in that manner. Just like that, here too, the brahmin realized that his own mind was the root cause of the arising of this sorrow—that it was something that sprang from within his own mind. Then, when the Buddha declared, "**Taṇhāya vippamuttassa natthi soko kuto bhayaṃ**" [For one freed from craving (**taṇhā**), there is no sorrow, whence fear?], the brahmin understood that eradicating this craving (**taṇhā**) right there was something within his own power. The crop that was washed away could not be recovered. There was no remedy for that. Instead of that, refusing food and sleeping, or moving toward death through fasting, was not the remedy. Then, the ultimate result of the revolution that occurred in the mind of the brahmin who understood that reality was the attainment of the fruit of the path of stream-entry, which is nobler even than universal emperorship (**cakkavatti** reign). This story began with him being a wrong-viewed brahmin. Now, virtuous friends, along with the attainment of this fruit of stream-entry, a person is known as a Noble One (**ariya-puggala**). He attained a noble state. He attained a supreme state. Right view (**sammā-diṭṭhi**) arose. Such a massive mental revolution occurred. This brahmin might not have been a learned man. He was also a poor man. Yet, such a great thing took place here because there is a profound Dhamma in this. It is something worth directing our minds to. Now, these days, something we often hear is: "This is not the time to focus on the deep aspects of the Dhamma. This is a time of much hardship, distress, and calamity. We should think about that Nibbāna, about those deep things, only after this country overflows with milk and honey." Some people think like that. But, virtuous friends, in the world, there is a kind of thing called "blessings in disguise." Some calamities and disasters come just like blessings. Now, for this brahmin, the desolation of this field became a great blessing. Because of the mental revolution that arose through it, this brahmin was able to attain that sublime, noble state—which is nobler than universal emperorship, and which the Buddha praised in an extraordinary way.

Thus, through these disasters, calamities, and shocks, we can bring to light these Four Noble Truths: suffering (**dukkha**), its cause, its stilling which is realized as extinguishment—Nibbāna—and the way to it, the practice—the Noble Eightfold Path. When we reflect on bringing forth insight-knowledge through these calamities, and when we think about that knowledge—about education—our minds often run to universities, which are so common nowadays. They have an artistic name, "Sarasavi" (abode of the goddess of learning). Many people try to enter these **sarasavis**. Those who have entered them make great efforts to leave them—to pass out—successfully. But, virtuous friends, most people do not know that we are all in a certain **sarasavi**. It is called the "University of Life" (**jīvita sarasaviya**). In other universities, there are various kinds of sciences, arts, and technologies to learn. In this University of Life, there are only three subjects to

pass, to master. What are they? The Buddha has shown them as: *assāda* (gratification), *ādīnava* (danger), and *nissaraṇa* (escape). *Assāda* refers to the side of gratification—enjoyment—the fivefold cords of sensual pleasure, gratification. This is the first lesson. I think everyone present here has passed this lesson thoroughly. Every samsaric being has passed this fivefold sensual pleasure. The next lesson is *ādīnava* [danger]. That refers to the hardships one has to undergo in pursuing those fivefold sensual pleasures—for their sake—the undesirable consequences in life, and so forth. Troubles, hardships, calamities, disasters—all these fall under the category of danger (*ādīnava*). The side of gratification is little, the side of danger is much, yet most people remain in the class of gratification. They are not even inclined to think about the danger. They do not even direct their minds to look at them. But, virtuous friends, it is through this danger (*ādīnava*) that one can proceed to the next class. *Nissaraṇa* means the escape from *saṃsāra*. *Saṃsāra* (wandering on) means moving around in this cycle, like spinning in one place. Now, you devotees know that if a vehicle travels a long distance, that distance is recorded. But no matter how far it goes, what happens? The wheel spins in the very same spot. In the same way, looking at it from one perspective, we have traveled in this *saṃsāra* for an infinite time. We use the words "vast *saṃsāra*." We employ such terms. But what of having gone this far? It is just spinning in the same place. We can also take it as the spinning of the wheel in the manner of birth (*jāti*), aging and death (*jarāmaraṇa*), sickness, and death. Or else, it is just the effort one exerts to fulfill those various expectations one hopes for. There is no end to that either. It is like the wheel spinning in the very same place.

So, in this way, wandering in *saṃsāra* is a spinning in the very same place, or a wandering about. Likewise, *nissaraṇa* means leaping out of that circle, departing, escaping from *saṃsāra*. It is this grade of *nissaraṇa*—this subject of *nissaraṇa*—this lesson of *nissaraṇa*—that we have to pass. In this world, in this era, the supreme one who first passed and mastered these three lessons in this University of Life is the Buddha. Accordingly, the Arahants too. Now this brahmin too obtained the first noble state called the fruit of stream-entry in that university. If we learn lessons from this University of Life according to the occasion, that is what remains for life. That is what supports one's liberation (*vimukti*). The Buddha has shown through various similes how noble this liberation obtained through the fruit of stream-entry is. On one occasion, taking a tiny amount of soil on the tip of his fingernail, the Buddha asked the community of monks, "Is this soil on my fingernail more, or is the soil of the great earth more?" The monks replied, "Venerable Sir, this soil on the fingernail is very little. The soil of the great earth is indeed much more." Drawing upon that simile, the Buddha declared that the amount of *saṃsāra* suffering (*dukkha*) that a

stream-enterer has escaped from and finished is like the soil of the great earth. What is left to be finished is extremely little, like the soil on the fingernail. Why is that? A stream-enterer is born in *saṃsāra* only seven more times at most. Furthermore, he does not go to the lower realms (*apāya*). That is a massive—extraordinary—solace. For a person who is not a stream-enterer, the lower realms are like his own home. There is no knowing at what moment, due to what kind of bad karma, he will have to go to the lower realms. Because of the transformation of the revolution that arose in the stream-enterer's mind, due to that noble state, due to the arising of that eye of Dhamma (*dhamma-cakkhu*) through insight-knowledges, the capacity to perform unwholesome deeds that lead to the lower realms is destroyed. None of the unwholesome deeds done in the past will lead him to the lower realms again. It is such an extraordinary liberation that one receives even from the fruit of stream-entry. That is why the Buddha declared that the samsaric suffering (*dukkha*) still to be endured by a stream-enterer is like the soil on the fingernail, while the samsaric suffering (*dukkha*) he has freed himself from is like the remaining soil of the great earth. He has shown other similes in the same way. It is like two or three drops of water taken from the great ocean compared to the remaining suffering (*dukkha*) to be endured. The mass of suffering (*dukkha*) endured—the mass of suffering (*dukkha*) escaped from—is like the remaining water in the great ocean. He has shown another similar simile: if the Himalaya mountain range were to gradually wear away until only seven tiny pebbles, the size of mustard seeds, remained—those seven pebbles are like the remaining suffering (*dukkha*) left for the stream-enterer to endure. The mass of suffering (*dukkha*) he is freed from is like the portion of the Himalayas that has worn away. In this way, various similes have been shown. There are four paths and fruits: Stream-entry (*sotāpatti*), Once-returning (*sakadāgāmi*), Non-returning (*anāgāmi*), and Arahantship (*arahatta*). One can understand what a massive thing, what a noble thing, the liberation obtained even from the first of these is.

Then, that wrong-viewed brahmin—who was leaning on his hoe and clearing weeds, addressing the Buddha as "Venerable Gotama"—after that crop was destroyed, attained that fruit of stream-entry which the Buddha considers nobler than universal emperorship, nobler than sovereignty over the entire world, and nobler even than going to heaven. From this, we can see that what are called the deep Dhamma—what are called "insight-knowledges" (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*)—are not things limited only to the learned, to degree holders, or to those who went to universities. If you virtuously-disposed devotees who engage in agriculture also think of utilizing your University of Life, these can be attained. Now, because that wrong-viewed brahmin possessed some deep merit-power, the moment he heard the Dhamma-stanza of the Buddha, such a transformation took place. You

devotees might feel a little doubt: why did the Buddha, the foremost in the three worlds, when there was so much work to be done, when there were so many matters concerning the community of monks, visit the place where this brahmin was plowing his field several times? The Buddha did not go there waiting for the brahmin's field to ripen to get a portion of the harvest. He went there waiting for the brahmin's mind to ripen, to bestow a portion of the harvest of the deathless, great Nibbāna he had attained. The brahmin's mind ripened on the very day that harvest was destroyed. Sometimes, your minds too ripen when calamities and disasters strike. In this day and age, there is no need to speak anew about these things—how one's children, relatives, and loved ones lose their lives in various circumstances. Sometimes through incurable diseases, sometimes through great shocks, they meet destruction amidst great blazes of fire. Even after receiving such lessons in the University of Life, because they do not direct their minds to them, Buddhists cannot even achieve what that wrong-viewed brahmin was able to do for himself. Instead, some such people think that thinking about these deep Dhammas—Nibbāna, the supramundane paths and fruits—is only for a time when this country is prosperous and overflowing with milk and honey. "Until then, let us look to build up the economy. Never mind what happens to righteousness." Such are the opinions that exist in the world. But you devotees can understand through this small story—nowadays, you devotees read stories, short stories, novels, and so on, with great relish. There is no example to be taken from them, only amusement. But through Dhamma stories, through the accounts of lives, the lessons we can learn are many. When reading about the life accounts of the monks and nuns in this Dispensation, and the life accounts of laymen and laywomen, it becomes clear that for many, this noble Dhamma of Nibbāna was realized at times when they faced massive life-shattering shocks. The stories of Kisā Gotamī, Paṭācārā, and various others like Aṅgulimāla, show that it was through those experiences amidst great life struggles that they realized the Four Noble Truths. Therefore, we too have such opportunities. It is to those that we referred as "blessings in disguise." What are called "blessings in disguise" appear to us as calamities. They appear to us as disasters, as shocks. But for what purpose do those shocks occur? In *saṃsāra*, a certain moment arrives as the "opportunity of the moment" (*khaṇa-sampatti*). The Buddha has shown the value of this *khaṇa-sampatti*. The "moment" (*khaṇa*) means an instant. The Buddha has declared, "Do not let the noble moment pass."

Khaṇo ve mā upaccagā

Khaṇātītā hi socanti

Nirayamhi samappitā

"Do not let the noble moment—the auspicious juncture—pass by. For if it passes, you will have to fall into hell and suffer." What is this noble moment?

On certain occasions, the Buddha declared that many in the world say, "**khaṇakicceva loko, khaṇakicceva loko**"—that this world is a place where work is done by the moment, where work is done on time. Nowadays, time is so chaotic that it is almost impossible to keep track of. But what the Buddha referred to as the "auspicious juncture" (**nakkhatta**) is the intelligent human life-state obtained during the time of a Buddha's appearance. It is when many factors come together that one can obtain an intelligent human life-state during the time of a Buddha's appearance. Even if a Buddha arises, if one were born in the animal realm, the realm of hungry ghosts (**peta**), the realm of **asuras**, or in hell, there would be no opportunity to incline toward the Dhamma, live according to the Dhamma, realize Nibbāna, and escape from **saṃsāra**. But if, during the time of a Buddha's appearance, in a place where that Dhamma exists, one has obtained a human life-state, free from physical or mental disabilities, and with the power of intelligence—that is what is called **khaṇa-sampatti** (the opportunity of the moment). It is to make use of that **khaṇa-sampatti** that the Buddha constantly advises us. He has shown its value. Why? Especially as mentioned here, the stream-enterer escapes from hell—the very first escape. Everyone must reflect: escape from **saṃsāra**—from the entirety of **saṃsāra**—is obtained through Arahantship; but even before that, a wonderful kind of liberation obtained through the first fruit of the path is the escape—the deliverance—from the terrifying state of going to the lower realms. The Buddha and the Great Arahants possessing direct-knowledge (**abhiññā**) have declared that for infinite time, world beings suffer immense pain in the animal realm, the ghost realm, the **asura** realm, and in hell. Since such a calamitous, risky situation exists in the world—in life—one must learn lessons through the disasters and calamities one experiences, through the experiences in these terrifying periods, without pushing aside these noble states, insight-knowledges, the paths and fruits, and the Four Noble Truths. Some people solve the very same math problem every day. They solve it and solve it, but it is wrong. The right answer does not come. In just the same way, beings in this **saṃsāra** wander on, unable to understand these Four Noble Truths. The Buddha himself has declared: "Monks, it is because of not knowing these Four Noble Truths that both you and I have wandered in this **saṃsāra** for such an infinite time, covered by ignorance and bound by craving (**taṇhā**)." One must utilize the experiences of life to realize the Four Noble Truths. If any disasters or calamities come, that is the truth of suffering (**dukkha**) declared by the Buddha. Just like that brahmin understood, "A part of that has come to me; at the bottom of this lies craving (**taṇhā**)." That is something done through wise attention [**yoniso manasikāra**].

What is called wise attention [**yoniso manasikāra**] is wise reflection. If things spring from a certain place, looking right there—at that. If one looks away from there, the truth of it will never be understood. What is called **ayoniso manasikāra** is inappropriate reflection. In fact, the Buddha has declared that there are four factors that help one to become a stream-enterer: **sappurisa-saṃsevo, saddhamma-savanaṃ, wise attention [yoniso-manasikāro], dhammānudhamma-paṭipatti**. **Sappurisa-saṃsevo** means association with virtuous people, association with a spiritual friend (**kalyāṇa-mitta**). **Saddhamma-savanaṃ** means hearing the true Dhamma—listening to the sublime Dhamma. **Yoniso-manasikāro** means wise attention. Next, **dhammānudhamma-paṭipatti** means practicing in accordance with the Dhamma—the Noble Eightfold Path. Thus, these four. Now, someone might doubt whether these four were completed for that brahmin. But for someone who has fulfilled them in past **saṃsāra**, that deep understanding can be gained with a very slight stimulus. Understanding comes to different individuals in different ways. Even among you devotees, there are those who understand when a little is said. There is a saying in society: "I understand even as someone turns." Just like that. There were those who understood even as they turned. When the Buddha just used a word or two, there were those who understood through that alone and realized Nibbāna. For some, it has to be explained at length. For some, various expedients must be employed. Here too, the Buddha, in order to cultivate faith in that brahmin, went to the field constantly, behaving like an intimate visitor. The Buddha saw that such a great loss was going to happen to the brahmin. It was not that he did not see it—not that he expected a portion of the harvest. But gradually, taking special trouble for his sake, he carried the Buddha's Dispensation to that brahmin. The result of that was the brahmin's attainment of liberation.

In that way, you devotees too must make an effort to understand the true state of life, to understand the nature of **saṃsāra**, through the life struggles and disasters you encounter. Do not always remain in the class of gratification (**assāda**) as if you are in a good class. The Buddha declared that there is a side of danger (**ādīnava**) to this. "I went in search of the side of gratification in the world. Whatever gratification there is in the world, I understood that. Next, I went in search of the side of danger. That state of danger too, I understood. Next, I researched the escape (**nissaraṇa**)—the departure—from the world." He also uses that word "research." That is something used nowadays in scholarly works—"research." Two terms have been used: **anariya-pariyesana** and **ariya-pariyesana**—the ignoble search and the noble search, the inappropriate search and the appropriate search. Thus, the Buddha, through this noble search, realized that escape—Nibbāna. Having realized it, the Buddha then helped the beings of

the world—devas, humans, poor individuals of that sort, men and women who had fallen victim to various harassments, great bandits, those of corrupted character, and likewise monks, various sectarians, wanderers (*paribbājakas*), Nigaṇṭhas, and so on—everyone. He saw that these beings also had certain good qualities from their past *saṃsāra*. Delivering sermons of a nature that subdued their bad qualities, he brought them to the practice in accordance with the Dhamma. Here, that association with virtuous people (*sappurisa-saṃsevo*) helps. Next, hearing the true Dhamma. That brahmin received all four of these at once. The supreme spiritual friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*) in the world visited the field—that house—of that brahmin. Thus, the gain of a virtuous person was obtained. As the hearing of the true Dhamma, even those stanza lines sufficed. Next, wise attention [*yoniso manasikāra*]. The brahmin directed his mind, turned to look at his mind instead of the sight of the field, and understood that truth. Through wise attention [*yoniso manasikāra*], the path was cleared for the practice in accordance with the Dhamma (*dhammānudhamma-paṭipatti*). Now, sometimes, someone might think that this means applying the entirety of the Noble Eightfold Path throughout one's whole life. Indeed, such application is necessary for a person. But for someone who has fulfilled those Dhammas in the past, that practice in accordance with the Dhamma is completed in a very short time. If someone detaches their mind from the world and refrains from food, saying "I do not want life," that person has few defilements. Though they have given up expectation for life with a wrong idea, yet, on such an occasion, the moment this Dhamma fell upon the brahmin, the Noble Eightfold Path must have been completed within his mind. That is something extremely profound.

Now you devotees know that many are eager to see the colors of a rainbow—especially small children. When looking at the sky at a time when it is about to rain, it is something we can see only rarely. But even if we cannot see it like that all the time, we can see the beautiful colors of the sun in a rainbow by looking at a tiny dewdrop hanging from a leaf of a creeper, exactly in line with the rising sun. It shines like a gem. Within it, those rays can be seen. Through a dewdrop, one can see something like a rainbow. In the same way, through a small stanza—a line of a stanza, a word—if someone looks exactly in line with the target, if they establish right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*), they can see Nibbāna through it. The mental revolution that occurred within that brahmin was such a thing.

Thinking deeply in that manner, we can take many examples from this Dhamma story. In the same way, we must constantly reflect on how our lives are spent, on the true nature of life. The Buddha has shown the true nature, the reality of this life (this word is used in society now)—"things as they really are"—in four sentences, in four Dhamma themes. These four are:

1. *Upanīyati loko addhuvo* (The world is swept away, it is impermanent (*anicca*))
2. *Atāṇo loko anabhissaro* (The world is without protection, without a ruler)
3. *Assako loko sabbam pahāya gamanīyam* (The world has nothing of its own, all must be left behind and gone)
4. *Ūno loko atitto taṇhā dāso* (The world is insufficient, insatiable, a slave to craving (*taṇhā*))

We get an excellent exposition of these four Dhamma themes from Venerable Raṭṭhapāla. Venerable Raṭṭhapāla is one who received the foremost position among those who went forth out of faith in this Dispensation. On many occasions, the Buddha gave foremost positions in various fields to his disciples. In wisdom, Venerable Sāriputta is foremost. Among those of psychic power, the great Venerable Moggallāna is foremost. Among attendants, Venerable Ānanda is foremost. Nowadays, in universities too, various degrees are given in that manner. That is as an example to the world. If you want wisdom, look this way. If you want psychic powers, look that way. If you want matters of personal service, look this way. In that manner, if you want to see the power in faith, the extraordinary miracle in faith, look at Venerable Raṭṭhapāla. Because Venerable Raṭṭhapāla, having heard the Dhamma from the Buddha once, asked permission from his parents to go forth. Venerable Raṭṭhapāla belonged to an extremely wealthy family. When he asked permission from his parents at that young age, permission was not granted. He lay down on the floor right there. "Either death, or permission to go forth," he said. He began a fast unto death. Finally, unable to resolve this, his friends gathered, spoke to the parents, and somehow obtained permission for him to go forth. After Venerable Raṭṭhapāla became an Arahant, he visited his home village. When he visited the Kuru country, King Koravya of that Kuru country asked Venerable Raṭṭhapāla, "Venerable Raṭṭhapāla, having been born in such a wealthy family, at such a young age, why did you go forth? What was the reason to go forth?" On that occasion, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla said, "It is after hearing four Dhamma themes declared by the Buddha—four Dhamma themes that declare the reality of life—knowing their state, seeing them, and understanding them to be true, that I went forth. It was not for nothing." We mentioned what these four points are.

He declared to the king: the nature of the world is "*Upanīyati loko addhuvo*"—"The world is an unstable place, swept forward." The king asked him to explain this, since it seemed a bit like a riddle. Then, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla, by way of explaining it, asked the king: "Great King, when you were about twenty or

twenty-five years old, how was it? Did you have good physical strength, bodily vigor? Were you skilled in managing the elephant, horse, chariot, and infantry forces, in riding elephants and horses, and in the arts of swordplay and archery?" "Oh yes, at that time, I felt that there was no one as powerful, as strong as I. I even felt that I possessed psychic powers. To that extent, I had physical power and strength." Then, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla asked, "Well, Great King, is it the same now?" "Oh, it is not so now. Now I am about eighty years old. A decrepit old man. Now sometimes when I mean to place my foot here, I place it there. Even my limbs are not under my control." "This, Great King, is what the Buddha declared: '*Upanīyati loko addhuvo*', the world is swept forward by decay. This is an impermanent (*anicca*) thing. The world is impermanent (*anicca*)—what is called 'the world' is worldlings—life; this is that very truth of life." Then the king declared, "It is wonderful, Venerable Sir, it is marvelous, this matter. How true is what the Buddha declared!" Thus, the truth, the reality regarding the life of an extremely poor person as well as the life of a great king, is what the Buddha declared through this line of Dhamma.

Next, concerning the second point, the king asked Venerable Raṭṭhapāla: "Venerable Sir, why did you declare '*Atāṇo loko anabhissaro*'? " The general meaning of that is "The world is a place without protection, without a ruler." Even nowadays, if that is said, one is startled. "The world is a place without protection, without a ruler: why was that declared?" The king asked, "I have elephant, horse, chariot, and infantry forces. I have so much protection. Why was this declared?" Then, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla asked the king, "Great King, do you have any chronic illness?" The king declared, "Yes, Venerable Sir, I have a severe wind-illness (*vātābādha*). On some occasions, when that wind-illness becomes acute, my relatives and friends surround me, and I hear them saying, 'Now King Koravya will pass away, he will die.'" Then, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla asked, "Great King, on such occasions, can you tell those relatives and friends, 'Oh, please, gather together and share a little of my pain, reduce my pain'? Can you do that? Can you share your pain with those relatives and friends of yours and obtain relief?" "I cannot do that," the king declared. "That, Great King, is what the Buddha declared: '*Atāṇo loko anabhissaro*'. The world is a place without protection, without a ruler. One cannot obtain protection in such situations." Then too, the king accepted it, saying, "What a wonderful, marvelous matter!"

Next, the king asked: "Now, in this royal palace, I have gold, silver, pearls, gems, and much wealth and grain. While having these, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla, why do you declare '*Assako loko sabbam pahāya gamanīyam*'? " The meaning of that is: the world is a place where there is nothing one can call one's own, a place where everything must be left behind and gone. When asked about the meaning of this

statement, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla inquired: "Now, Great King, you live well, enjoying these fivefold cords of sensual pleasure. When going to the next world, can you take these with you? Or do you have to hand them over to someone here and go? You have to abandon them and go, do you not?" "It is just so, Venerable Sir, I cannot take even one of these with me. I go to the next world in accordance with my own karma; taking the good and bad I have done, I go to the next world," the king said. "This, Great King, is what the Buddha declared: there is nothing in the world one can call one's own, everything must be abandoned and gone." The king accepted that.

Next, what is declared finally is also what is relevant to the stanza we recalled on this occasion—"*Ūno loko atitto taṇhā dāso*". The king asked about the meaning of this too. The meaning of that passage is: "The world is a place with a constant deficiency, insatiable, a slave to craving (*taṇhā*)." Then, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla, to make the king realize it, asked several questions: "Now, Great King, you reign as the ruler of this Kuru country, which is highly prosperous, do you not?" "Yes." "Now, some spy, or a trustworthy person, comes to meet you. Having arrived, he tells you this news: 'I am coming from the eastern direction. In that direction, there is a very wealthy and prosperous country. You can conquer it very easily.' When that is said, Great King, what do you do regarding that—when such news is received?" "I will conquer that country too." "Next, he asks: 'Very well, in the same way, a messenger comes from the western direction and says: "In that direction, Your Majesty, there is such a large territory, you can conquer it very easily."' "Then I will capture that too, I will conquer that too.' In the same way, from the northern direction, and from the southern direction." When the king declared in this manner, Venerable Raṭṭhapāla drove the point home: "It is because of that, Great King, that the Buddha declared: 'The world is a place with some kind of deficiency.' All the time, something is needed. Never is one satisfied. A slave to craving (*taṇhā*). The king too has become a slave to craving (*taṇhā*). The king thinks he is the sovereign. Now, in this day and age too, there are those who hold various titles of 'sovereign' (*adhipati*). Even though the word 'sovereign' has a general meaning, all these people are slaves to craving—'slaves to craving (*taṇhā*)'. The king too is a slave to craving (*taṇhā*)." "

Then, escaping from this state of being a slave to craving is what is called freeing oneself from craving (*taṇhā*). Nibbāna is the stilling of this thirst of craving (*taṇhā*), the occasion when that thirst is stilled. Like a feverish patient asking for water, this craving (*taṇhā*) has pushed us through *saṃsāra* for an infinite time. This is never stilled, even if one is replete with the most exquisite things, the most valuable luxury items. When thinking about the luxury and wealth of a universal monarch (*cakkavatti*), the pleasures enjoyed by the wealthy in those

countries called "developed" nowadays are "beggarly pleasures"; universal monarchs have enjoyed such vast pleasures. Yet, even with that, they were not satisfied. This is the nature of craving (*taṇhā*). This fire can never be extinguished by adding firewood to it. Instead, right where that fire arose—right there—it must be extinguished, just as that brahmin eradicated his craving (*taṇhā*) right there regarding his field. At the same time, he gained a deep understanding. "This is the trick to escaping from *saṃsāra*, this is the secret here"—because the brahmin understood this, he attained the state of stream-entry. It is by bringing to light this principle through the life struggles, disasters, and calamities one encounters, that one can utilize that blessing in disguise. Because of that, whether they appear as calamities of the times, or whether they are various other revolutions that occur in the world, we must look to bring to light this Buddha's Dispensation through them. "Buddha's Dispensation" (*Buddha Śāsanaya*) is a big word, a heavy word. Nowadays, there is a tendency for only the sound of words to remain while the meaning slips away. Especially, the sound of words related to the Dhamma increases more and more, but the meaning slips away. One such word is "Buddha's Dispensation." Nowadays, if "Buddha's Dispensation" is mentioned, buildings come to mind. Various things must come to mind when "Buddha's Dispensation" is mentioned. But when thinking deeply, the very Buddha's Dispensation that the Great Arahant Mahinda brought to Sri Lanka and handed over to King Devanampiyatissa is what the Buddha went to that poor brahmin's house and gave. The ultimate goal of that Buddha's Dispensation is Nibbāna. The philosophy of life is the Noble Eightfold Path, right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*), and the Four Noble Truths. The practice of life is the path of virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*). This is the Buddha's Dispensation. Thus, it is this Buddha's Dispensation that Buddhist devotees must bring to mind and protect on a day like today.

The things that help to protect this Buddha's Dispensation are what we mentioned. Now, it was declared that four factors help to attain the state of stream-entry. Association with virtuous people (*sappurisa-saṃseva*)—when reflecting on daily life, this is a factor that must be utilized with much mind-application and care, this "association with virtuous people." The person called "virtuous" (*sappurisa*) is introduced in the Dhamma as a spiritual friend (*kalyāṇa-mitta*). A spiritual friend is a layperson or a monk who possesses Dhamma-knowledge, lives according to the Dhamma, and practices meditation. The one who leads a life in accordance with the Dhamma is the virtuous person. Such a virtuous person is like a lighthouse to society. He is like a lamp-post (*pahan kanuwa*). You devotees know well what a lamp-post is. A lamp-post is an object that gives light to others. In the same way, the person called a "virtuous person," a "spiritual friend," is a lamp-post. The greatest lamp-post in the world

is the Buddha, the foremost in the three worlds—the Buddha who diffused that light of Dhamma. Next to him is the Community of Noble Monks (*Ariya-saṅgha*) of the eight noble individuals. Or else, those lay or ordained devotees who lead a life in accordance with the Dhamma and practice meditation. Every such person is a lighthouse, a lamp-post, a virtuous person, a spiritual friend. It is by associating with such spiritual friends that one's progress is ensured, and samsaric liberation can be obtained. When thinking on the other hand, it is bad friends (*pāpa-mitta*) who are in the majority in the world, in the majority in society. Keeping such persons at a distance as much as possible, if possible avoiding them altogether, being wary of them, one must lead one's life. Why? Because through association with bad friends, one meets with terrifying destruction.

On one occasion, Venerable Ānanda, going to express the value of this association with spiritual friends, said to the Buddha: "Venerable Sir, as it appears to me, spiritual friendship (*kalyāṇa-mittatā*) is half of the Buddha's Dispensation; half of this Buddha's Dispensation is valued as spiritual friendship." The Buddha declared: "Ānanda, do not say so. It is not half of this Buddha's Dispensation, but the entirety of the Buddha's Dispensation is spiritual friendship. What is called the Buddha's Dispensation is spiritual friendship, the fortune of a spiritual friend." Now, you devotees have gathered here due to some spiritual friendship. You might not know one another. Personally, you might not be people with individual relationships. But in terms of the Dhamma—in terms of listening to the Dhamma, in being devoted to the Dhamma—the quality of a spiritual friend is there. It is in that manner that a Buddha's Dispensation exists. Through association with bad friends, the Dispensation falls into decline. Going in search of spiritual friends, associating with them, taking from them what should be taken—taking help—is how a Buddha's Dispensation has to be protected. Association with virtuous people—"association with virtuous people" (*sappurisa-saṃsevo*)—is an extremely rare thing. The Buddha has shown six rare things:

1. *Dullabho buddhuppādo lokasmiṃ* (Rare is the appearance of a Buddha in the world)
2. *Dullabho manussattapaṭilābho* (Rare is the acquisition of a human birth)
3. *Dullabhā khaṇasampatti* (Rare is the opportunity of the moment)
4. *Dullabho pabbajjā* (Rare is ordination)
5. *Dullabhaṃ saddhammassavanaṃ* (Rare is the hearing of the true Dhamma)

6. *Dullabho sappurisa-saṃsevo* (Rare is association with virtuous people)

The time of a Buddha's appearance is extremely rare. Human birth is extremely rare. In the same way, the opportunity of the moment (*khaṇasampatti*) is rare. What we mentioned—the intelligent human life-state, free from disabilities, obtained during the time of a Buddha's appearance—is *khaṇasampatti*. That too is rare. Nobler than that, ordination is rare. Next, nobler than that, hearing the Dhamma is rare. More than all of those, finally, association with virtuous people (*sappurisa-saṃsevo*) is the rarest. Association with virtuous people is just like the bullseye in the center of a target board. Why? Because even though the time of a Buddha's appearance is rare, within it, many other factors must come together for someone to attain liberation. Even if one obtains the time of a Buddha's appearance, a human birth must be obtained. Along with human birth, the opportunity of the moment, ordination, and next, the hearing of the Dhamma. In this way, the factors become extremely rare one by one. If proper association with a spiritual friend is obtained, then for such a person, Nibbāna is hastened. For that brahmin, as if by fortune, the supreme spiritual friend in the world was met. It is because of that that he attained that state so quickly. In the same way is the hearing of the true Dhamma. One must listen to the Dhamma that leads to Nibbāna, incline one's ear to it, direct one's mind to it. One must make an effort to understand the Dhamma. Hearing the Dhamma is not to be done as a mere custom. Gathering together the group of Dhammas within oneself that help toward Nibbāna, directing the mind, focusing the mind to the extent of obtaining the realization of the paths and fruits even during that occasion of hearing the Dhamma, listening with concentration—that is how the Dhamma should be heard. Next, it is during such an occasion of hearing the Dhamma that wise attention [*yoniso manasikāra*]—wise reflection—occurs. Now, that brahmin reflected wisely and, while looking at the field, suddenly began to look at his mind by way of wise attention [*yoniso manasikāra*]. Next, the mental revolution that occurs due to such looking is what is called the practice in accordance with the Dhamma (*dhammānudhamma-paṭipatti*). For certain persons, it is completed in a single moment. But for most, it has to be practiced as a preliminary part over a long period. That is how one's pattern of life must be shaped. That pattern of life is what is called the Noble Eightfold Path. Through that Noble Eightfold Path of *sammā-diṭṭhi, sammā-saṅkappa, sammā-vācā, sammā-kammanta, sammā-ājīva, sammā-vāyāma, sammā-sati, sammā-samādhi*, a person's entire life is shaped in accordance with the Dhamma.

Sammā-diṭṭhi means right view—the right philosophy of life. Understanding good and bad, wholesome and unwholesome, having gained some level of understanding of the Four Noble Truths of suffering (*dukkha*), its cause, its

stilling which is Nibbāna, and the way to it, the Noble Eightfold Path, one puts that view—that right view—at the forefront. It is declared: "**Sammā-diṭṭhi pubbaṅgamā**." Everywhere, view is chief, it is at the forefront. Now, even when you devotees walk on the road, why do you look ahead? By looking ahead, you establish some resolution, some determination, regarding the place you are going. In the same way, if there is an understanding of the Four Noble Truths through right view, one establishes the target of Nibbāna, saying "My journey is a journey to Nibbāna, a journey going toward Nibbāna." "Buddha's Dispensation" means a way of life that has Nibbāna as its target, not buildings. Then, if right view—right seeing—has arisen, next there are right thoughts and intentions that go in accordance with right seeing. In accordance with that philosophy of life, one must cultivate good thoughts and concepts—good thoughts. Thoughts of loving-kindness (**mettā**) opposed to ill-will, thoughts of non-harming (**avihiṃsā**) opposed to cruelty—one must constantly develop these thoughts. If right thoughts and intentions have arisen in that manner, the words that come out from that person are also correct words, truthful words, words that do not divide others, gentle words that are not harsh, words in accordance with the Dhamma. In that way, they use good words. Next, the courses of action are abstaining from the wrongs done by the body: killing living beings, stealing, and sexual misconduct. Next, right livelihood is what is mentioned in the livelihood-as-the-eighth virtue (**ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla**) that we undertook on this occasion. It spoke about abstaining from wrong livelihood (**micchā-ājīva**). These days, many, enslaved by the effort to build up the economy, turn to wrong livelihoods. Whether they did those due to poverty or other reasons, it is because those help one to go to terrifying places like hell in this **saṃsāra** that the Buddha prohibited them. What are they? Trading in weapons, trading in living beings for meat, trading in poisons, trading in flesh, trading in intoxicants. The Buddha declared that carrying on one's livelihood through these leads to one's decline. Sometimes, one can become rich quickly through these. But even though one becomes rich, it is because one will have to suffer their terrifying consequences that the Buddha prohibited them. Because of that, abstaining from wrong livelihood and establishing a good livelihood is a source of great solace for a person. There is no regret for such a person. That mind is constantly pure. That purity is not possessed even by a person with a massive amount of wealth. Or else, even someone with a large salary does not have that happiness—the happiness of one's own blamelessness. That is called the happiness of blamelessness (**anavajja-sukha**). The happiness regarding correctness, the absence of regret, is a great solace. A person who obtains a massive amount of wealth sometimes cannot sleep. He remembers that he obtained that wealth through improper means. Therefore, one who expects ultimate solace must necessarily consider one's own livelihood. Sometimes, some people are addicted

to ancestral wrong livelihoods. "We cannot abandon those jobs that came from our parents; those are what we have inherited as our custom; those are things we are used to." But if someone has properly understood the Buddha's word, regardless of the loss to themselves, they adjust their livelihood in accordance with the Dhamma. Sometimes, they turn to a righteous job that yields a small salary, a lower income. That is what is called establishing right livelihood (*sammā-ājīva*). Through the effort exerted to establish right livelihood, "right effort" (*sammā-vāyāma*) arises in that person. The correct effort is the exertion made to prevent unwholesome thoughts from entering one's mind, to remove unwholesome thoughts that are in the mind, to produce wholesome thoughts not yet in oneself, and to establish wholesome thoughts that are in oneself. It is to this fourfold effort that "right effort" (*sammā-vāyāma*) is called. The person who exerts effort in that manner, because of the mindfulness (*sati*) applied for that sake, lives with good mindfulness called "right mindfulness" (*sammā-sati*). Like a good watchman, they apply mindfulness well. If mindfulness is applied well, the Four Foundations of Mindfulness (*cattāro satipaṭṭhānā*) is well understood. One understands well regarding one's body, regarding feelings / sensations [*vedanā*], regarding the mind, and regarding the thoughts that come to the mind. It is by developing those Four Foundations of Mindfulness systematically that one can attain even those noble absorption states (*jhāna*) called right concentration (*sammā-samādhi*). If the Noble Eightfold Path is completed within someone in that manner, right there is Nibbāna. Supramundane-wise, along with the completion of the Noble Eightfold Path, one can obtain the realization of the paths and fruits called Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship.

Then, you devotees must reflect: if we talk about a Buddha's Dispensation on a day like today, what is called the Buddha's Dispensation is just that—the Noble Eightfold Path, the Four Noble Truths, or else the development of virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*). Except for describing it through such words, the Buddha's Dispensation cannot be described by way of other buildings or symbols. Therefore, if protecting that Buddha's Dispensation is our duty as Buddhists, we must also be eager to adjust our way of life and our outlook on life accordingly. The story presented in this Dhamma sermon is a simple, ordinary story. We should not discard these saying they are things in old books. Unlike those novels and short stories of these days, these are things directly relevant to the experiences of our University of Life. Therefore, you devotees must make an effort to realize Nibbāna through those very experiences. Especially, the occasion of hearing the Dhamma is—as declared by the Buddha—a place to obtain liberation, an avenue of liberation (*vimuttāyatana*). There are various kinds of liberations. But the Buddha has declared the places where

samsaric liberation is obtained. The occasion of hearing the Dhamma is such an occasion. The occasion of preaching the Dhamma is also such an occasion. Therefore, if you devotees have heard the Dhamma well, many wholesome thoughts that help toward that liberation—that help in life—must have arisen in your minds on this occasion. Utilizing that mass of wholesome feelings / sensations [*vedanā*] as a strong support (*upanissaya*), you must wish: "May we be able to escape from this extremely terrifying, dreadful *saṃsāra*, be freed from all samsaric suffering (*dukkha*) of birth (*jāti*), aging and death (*jarāmaṇa*), sickness, and death, and realize the sublime, deathless, great peace of Nibbāna, which is immeasurable and beyond reckoning!" In the same way, you must wish: "May the guardian deities and Brahmas of the Dispensation, and whatever assembly of deities are presiding over this place, and all those who desire Nibbāna, who desire merit, rejoice in this merit of preaching the Dhamma and hearing the Dhamma!" In the same way, you must make the wish: "May all beings, including one's own relatives and friends, from the lowest hell (*Avīci*) up to the highest heaven (*Akaniṭṭha*), whoever desire merit, whoever desire Nibbāna, rejoice in this merit of preaching the Dhamma and hearing the Dhamma, escape from all samsaric suffering (*dukkha*), and be solaced by the sublime, deathless, great peace of Nibbāna!" Having made this wish, now share the merit by reciting the stanzas in this manner:

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”